



“Art, that’s special. What can you bring to it that nobody else can?”

Mr. Turlington / Boyhood

to explain the effect they have on their audiences? When a viewer falls for a movie, it can feel like it has been made for them and them alone, like a hand extending from the screen. And yet, if you have ever watched a really great comedy in the middle of a packed cinema, or flinched to a horror alongside two hundred others doing exactly the same, you will know that movies are meant to be watched in a crowd, that cinema grew up as an experience to be shared with others.

Over the years, movies have been viewed in many different ways. At first, they were novelties, cheap dollops of sensation. Then they were impossibly glamorous moments of escapism whose stars glittered in pristine black and white. They evolved into profound accounts of the human condition, made by great auteurs. Today, they are often vastly expensive spectacles designed to make still more money for studios and corporations. They make you feel that you’ve slipped behind the eyes of the people on screen, the whole

thing not unlike a dream or an act of hypnosis, until you stumble back out into the light, maybe understanding something new about yourself, maybe just aching from laughing so hard.

A world of choice

Some of the movies in this book were adored by critics; others were pure crowd-pleasers. Quite a few were neither, flops that later generations then realized were masterpieces. Genre doesn’t come into it. Thrillers rub shoulders with Westerns, romance with neorealism, and they all have to make room for the occasional musical.

Language and nationality are no concern either. Hollywood is well represented—although many see it as a dirty word, the true movie lover knows how many good things Tinseltown has produced over the years. But there has always been a big world beyond Beverly Hills, and no worthwhile book about movies could ignore that. *The White Ribbon* (2009) deserves its place every bit as much as *Jaws* (1975).

There will, of course, be both omissions and inclusions that will puzzle each reader. Part of the beauty of cinema is that no two opinions on movies are ever quite the same. If this were just a list of the favorites of the consultant and authors, it would deviate in places from the list that follows. You might think the job of selection would get easier if the criterion were “greatness,” but really, that’s just as subjective. Rather, this book chooses its movies as an atlas of influence, a collection of landmarks, and the hope is that, if a reader’s own best-loved movie is missing, there will be others that make up for it. And also that there will be at least one movie that readers will choose to watch for the first time. ■

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When you clean them up, when you make movies respectable, you kill them.

Pauline Kael

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